



The Backlog the Department Could Not Count

Student copy (project or hand out)

- 1 In May 2026, the Department of Education filed a court-ordered status report and overstated the number of pending income-driven repayment applications for April by nearly 336,000. The Department attributed the gap to a servicer reporting error and put the corrected backlog at 1,649,874 pending applications. The reports are filed in a lawsuit the American Federation of Teachers brought against the Department, so the numbers are watched by the other side.
- 2 Everyone agrees on the starting point: a benefit only works if the records behind it are accurate. If a servicer's records are wrong, a borrower can be placed in the wrong repayment status, billed for the wrong amount, or made to wait on a refund that should already have arrived. That premise is not in dispute. It is the stated reason the system keeps the records at all.
- 3 Follow it one step. Accurate records do not maintain themselves; someone has to check the servicers. In February 2025, the Office of Federal Student Aid stopped reviewing the accuracy of loan servicers' records, citing a lack of staff. The staffing context is on the record: between January and December 2025, the office went from 1,433 employees to 777, a cut of 46 percent.
- 4 Checking mattered because the servicers had been failing the check. Before the reviews stopped, four of the five loan servicers did not meet the Department's standards for keeping accurate records, and they faced penalties of about \$850,000. The Government Accountability Office reported in March 2026 that the substitutes the Department named, its data quality assessments, its cross-system validation, its audits, its surveys, its SOC 1 reports, were not substitutes for checking servicer accuracy directly. In January 2026, the Department's own independent auditor had already labeled the reliability of its student loan data a material weakness.
- 5 The 336,000 sits at the end of that chain. A servicer fed a wrong number into a feed that fed a court report, and nothing in between caught it. The error was admitted, but only after it had already been filed. The same April reports also recorded a processing record: servicers cleared 456,594 IDR applications that month, the most to date. Progress and unreliability are running at the same time.
- 6 This is not the only seam showing. The backlog had once stood at 1,985,726 applications as of April 30, 2025; it is lower now. What the record leaves is a plain statement of condition: a benefit system whose own auditor flags its data, whose direct accuracy checks have been switched off, and whose headline figures still move by hundreds of thousands when somebody finally reconciles the feed. That is where it stands, pending the next report.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third and fourth paragraphs, the writer presents the end of servicer accuracy reviews and the prior failures of four of five servicers primarily in order to
 - A) show that the Government Accountability Office had recommended ending the accuracy reviews
 - B) argue that the staffing cuts at Federal Student Aid were the single cause of the backlog's growth
 - C) establish that the 336,000 overstatement was the predictable result of a documented chain, not an isolated slip
 - D) demonstrate that the loan servicers deliberately concealed inaccurate records from the Department
2. The writer quotes the auditor's phrase 'material weakness' and reports figures such as 1,649,874 and 456,594 rather than rounding them. In context, these choices most directly establish a tone that is
 - A) alarmed and urgent, using exact numbers to pressure the reader toward a conclusion
 - B) measured and on-the-record, letting precise figures and sourced terms carry weight the writer declines to editorialize
 - C) detached and indifferent, treating the borrowers behind the figures as beside the point
 - D) admiring of the Department's transparency in disclosing its own errors

Discussion questions:

1. The writer never states that the Department acted wrongly, yet a reader finishes with a clear sense of the system's condition. How does the dialectical chain (shared premise, stopped checks, prior failures, the resulting error) produce a judgment without the writer asserting one?
2. The piece reports a processing record (456,594 applications cleared in a single month) in the same paragraph as the data error. What does including a fact that cuts against the main line of concern do to the reliability of the writer's account?

Writing prompt (Homework or extended in-class, Q3 argument):

The opener traces how a benefit system can keep functioning, and even set processing records, while the data describing it grows unreliable after direct oversight is reduced. From this it implies a debatable proposition: that accurate measurement of a public program matters as much as the program's output, because a benefit administered on unreliable records cannot be trusted to reach the right people in the right amounts. Write an essay that defends, challenges, or qualifies the claim that accountability for a public service should rest on the reliability of its data as much as on the volume of work it produces. Use evidence from your reading, observation, or experience to support your line of reasoning.